THEATRE ▼

# MYTH MEETS MUSIC

**A NEW MUSICAL, *MAHABALI*, REIMAGINES THE RAMAYANA THROUGH HANUMAN'S EYES, BRINGING THE IMMEDIACY OF LIVE THEATRE TO THE EPIC**



**NEW AVATAR** Ankit Mohan plays Hanuman in *Mahabali*

Hanuman is the gift that keeps on giving. Of late, the Hindu god has inspired the 2024 Telugu superhero blockbuster *Hanu-man*, this year's Hindi blockbuster *Hanuman Ansh*, and is part of the Ramayana adaptation starring Ranbir Kapoor, in which Sunny Deol is essaying the role. There's no way the stage would be left behind.

Producers Randhir Ranjan Ray and Abhishek Narayan have put together a Broadway-style musical, *Mahabali*, rei-



**BACK TO HOMELAND** Padam Singh and Hira Devi in *Pyre;* (below) filmmaker Vinod Kapri

CINEMA ▼

# A Mountain Love Story

Filmmaker Vinod Kapri's *Pyre* explores ageing, migration and enduring companionship in a remote Uttarakhand village

Born in Secunderabad, filmmaker Vinod Kapri has the resilience and persistence of a mountain man. Inspired by an interaction with an old couple during a trek in Munsiyari, Uttarakhand, Kapri in 2022 directed a film about an octogenarian duo worried about who will do their last rites as villagers leave for the city. As if the remoteness of the location wasn't daunting enough, he cast two non-actors from the village. In 2024-25, he travelled with it to international festivals. *Pyre*, the small indie film, finally releases in cinemas on October 30.

Before that, Kapri was excited to take the film to three Uttarakhand towns—Srinagar, Bageshwar and Berinag—that have no cinemas. Having self-funded the film, he partnered with PictureTime Mobile Digital Movie Theatre to set up inflatable balloon theatres equipped with 5.1 surround sound (five speakers and one subwoofer) from October 14 to 17, bringing the big-screen experience to local audiences.

Shot in Purana Thal village in Berinag, *Pyre* taps into the anxieties of ageing parents whose children migrate and rarely return, while capturing the tenderness of a marriage in its twilight years. "I wanted a story where, despite the loneliness, the couple still want to live life," says Kapri. "To pass time, they will be like '*Chalo jhagda kar lete hain* [Let's fight]'." The bond he depicts between the couple, played

